



Summary of The Art of War

Original book by Sun Tzu

Successful victory during conflict requires more than just cunning and brawn. Whether you are involved in an individual conflict or are leading a group of people through a competition, the strategies required to prepare for and engage in battle are the same.

The Art of War by ancient Chinese warrior and philosopher Sun Tzu provides the essential elements that must be considered to develop strategic conflict resolution tactics. Sun Tzu's principles guide you through the steps required to become a competent leader and fighter. They teach you how to determine victory, when to engage in combat, and when to use intelligence and intimidation to dissolve conflict without confrontation. With these teachings, you'll understand how to read conflict and opponents to determine the best course of action.

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1-Page Summary

The Art of War by Sun Tzu is a renowned guide for how to engage in conflict and be successful in battle. Written more than two thousand years ago, Sun Tzu, a Chinese warrior and philosopher, details the nature of competition and psychology of leadership and provides strategies for how to approach both. Although his teachings are geared toward actual military conflict, the principles can be useful in all arenas of conflict or competition, even at a personal level.

Much of Tzu's teachings revolve around the concept that **victory without direct fighting is the most advantageous way to win**. Part of attaining this type of battle-free victory involves **five traits of successful military operations: the Way, the weather, the terrain, the leadership, and discipline**.

The Way describes the harmonious relationship between the government and civilian populace. When governments treat their people fairly and with respect, the people will be loyal and more apt to support government decisions when conflict arises. People will also be more willing to join in the conflict if they believe in the government they will be tasked to defend.

The weather means the literal seasons and conditions of whatever environment in which the battle will be waged. **Certain weather conditions are not conducive for a military campaign**. For instance, both winter and summer encompass dangerous conditions, such as blizzards or droughts, that can hinder the advancement, safety, health, and sustenance of a troop.

The terrain relates to the "lay of the land," meaning the geographical and physical factors of certain types of terrain. These factors make a parcel of land either advantageous or disadvantageous for advancement or battle. Factors to consider include distance to be traveled, the layout of the terrain and accompanying effort required to cross it, the size of the land, and safety and dangers encompassed in the geography.

The leadership describes the acuity and competence of the person charged with leading a fighting force. **A good leader should be intelligent, trustworthy, humane, courageous, and stern**. When all of these factors are at play, the leader is capable of making sound decisions and can count on the people to support them.

Discipline relates to the structure and organization of the personnel hierarchy. Determining who is best suited for high-ranking roles, who is capable of being brave, and who is weaker than the others is as important in determining a strong strategy as supplies are for the health of the troops.

You should consider how these five traits affect both your side and your opponent. **Only in knowing both your strengths and weaknesses, as well as those of the enemy, can you begin to form a strategic plan**. When you understand these traits, you will be able to assess the likelihood of victory in any circumstance. If victory is not certain, you should not engage in conflict.

Strategic Use of Resources

Part of a competent strategy is the intelligent use of resources. Resources relate to everything needed for battle, including food, troops, money, and weapons.

Once you've assessed the five traits, amassing and training your fighting contingent is the next priority. **You should only gather fighters when you deem the battle to be absolutely necessary** and believe victory is the likely outcome. Amassing a force before you determine this exploits the motivation, energy, and good

faith of the people. If you assemble forces too early, the public and troops will be weary when the need becomes a reality later.

Soldiers should be properly trained in combat tactics and shaped into a strong, loyal force through the use of rewards and punishments. **Rewards and punishments should not be arbitrary.** You should deliver both fairly across the ranks according to clear and legitimate boundaries. These types of **rewards and punishments motivate people for success.** Rewards and punishments handed out too readily or in a disparate manner will breed complacency and mistrust.

Reduce the use of supplies. You should avoid **lengthy battles**, which deplete food, money, and energy. When traveling great distances for battle, feeding off the enemy's abandoned stores ensures your stores are maintained. Only use weapons when all other strategies for victory have been exhausted.

Strategic Maneuvering of Troops

Momentum is the life force of any conflict. When momentum is on your side, you have the advantage. You can create this advantage by manipulating your enemy into action.

When the enemy is forced into action, they must adopt a certain formation. **The formation of both your troops and the enemy's speaks to the psychological conditions of each.** Therefore, if the enemy takes a certain form, you can deduce their strengths and weaknesses, using the latter to create a strategy for attack. To avoid allowing the enemy to have this information about your forces, you should remain formless.

Formlessness is a manifestation of defense. When victory is not certain, you should lay low, fortify your position, see to the health of your troops, and appear unorganized. **If your troops are unseen, your strategy cannot be known. If your strategy and strength are unknown, the enemy may be lulled into a state of complacency or bravado, both of which lead to careless behaviors.**

Wait for a vulnerability to appear in the enemy, then attack that weakness swiftly using orthodox and unorthodox offensive tactics. Orthodox tactics signify traditional formations and fighting techniques. These are standard modes of battle, such as structured face-to-face combat. **Unorthodox tactics include combat techniques outside the typical forms, including sneak attacks, espionage, and deception.** When used in harmony, both tactics can lead to advantages in battle.

Finally, when you have the advantage, you are in a state of fullness. If you lose the advantage and are forced into offense, you are in a state of emptiness. If you are empty but your opponent is full, victory cannot be guaranteed. If victory cannot be guaranteed, you should adopt a defensive position. **Fullness should only attack emptiness.** If both sides are full, wait until a vulnerability opens up in your opponent, then attack.

Gaining Advantages

The lay of the land should be considered a branch of your strategy. There are several types of terrain, each encompassing advantages or disadvantages, depending on the nature of the geographical structure. For instance, *easily passable terrain* allows either side to move freely in and out, whereas *unwelcoming terrain* hinders the movement of either side, thereby presenting only disadvantages. On easily passable terrain, you want to gain position first and wait for the enemy, giving you the advantage of preparation. On unwelcoming terrain, no advantage is attainable, so you should avoid entering this terrain and be wary of opportunities for gain.

Likewise, there are several grounds on which a fighting force may traverse, and each involves a psychological consideration and suggested action. For instance, ***light ground describes the fringe of enemy territory, whereas heavy ground describes a position deeply entrenched in enemy territory.*** On light ground, retreat is easy and your troops are not fully immersed in the conflict. You should move through light ground quickly so as not to allow the troops' motivation and mental commitment to wane. On heavy ground, retreat is more difficult. On this ground, your troops are resigned to the prospect of danger and will be more motivated to fight to the death.

Understanding the different types of terrain and grounds is as essential to determining victory as training and assessment of the five traits are.

The Goal Is to Win When It Is Easy

Strong leadership involves knowing when and how to mobilize during conflict. You must understand the constitution of your troops and officers and how to motivate them in varied circumstances. You must be cunning and intelligent in planning your strategy, but you must also be adaptable and capable of allowing the actions of the opponent to guide your decisions. The principles laid out in *The Art of War* will give you the wisdom and strategies you need to become this type of leader and learn how to seek victory when it can be attained swiftly and easily. **If you can be disciplined enough to only enter into battle when victory is assured, you can manage any conflict in your life.**

Shortform Introduction

The Art of War was written as a strategic handbook for how to navigate military conflict. The principles and suggestions provided throughout the book are geared toward armed struggle and the relationships between governments and military factions. Because of this, much of the language used throughout this summary involves military jargon and references. However, the teachings of this book are applicable to real-world scenarios, as well. Whenever possible, efforts have been made to use more general language. In places where the language is more jargon-heavy, we've translated the military terms and position categories into modern-day representations to help you understand how these principles relate to your personal experiences.

The actual text of Sun Tzu's words is pithy; Lionel Giles's classic 1910 translation of *The Art of War* is just 25 pages long. However, because of its pithiness, it can be undecipherable. As a result, a variety of translations have been published with further elaboration on Sun Tzu's words. We've based our summary on Thomas Cleary's translation, which includes line-by-line commentary by historical Chinese generals and scholars. In our summary, much of the elaboration and historical examples come from this commentary to augment Sun Tzu's words.

Chapter 1: General Overview of Conflict

Military action encompasses the health of an entire nation, as the success or failure of the action balances life and death. Because of this importance, **military conflict should be examined thoroughly before any action is taken.**

These examinations should happen on home ground and involve **five basic assessments: the Way, the weather, the terrain, the leadership, and discipline.**

Five Traits of Successful Military Action

The Way describes the harmonious relationship between the government and civilian populace. When the government treats its people with kindness and concern, the people are more apt to support government agendas and be loyal.

- This loyalty translates to support of military strategy and the willingness of those tapped to participate in the conflict.

To ensure success on the battlefield, **generating support at home is vital.** You gain trust in leadership when you treat all people equally, rules are clear and balanced, and punishment is just and distributed consistently and equally.

When support is strong at home, amassing a strong force becomes easier. However, the Way is also essential within the troops.

- **You ensure compliance when rules and commands are valid and well-articulated.**
- You foster respect and harmony among your subordinates when the varied roles within the rank hierarchy are articulated clearly and managed justly.
- Subordinates and superiors stand together under the same cause and are courageous in defending it when the Way is strong among the troops.

The Weather regards the appropriate season for battle. Leading a surge or entering a conflict in winter and summer can create unfavorable natural circumstances. Severe weather, such as blizzards or droughts, can stymie your troops through illness, other weather-related maladies, and depletion. Supplies can be compromised in inclement weather, as well.

The Terrain can be understood as “the lay of the land.” Geographical factors to consider include distance to be traversed, type of terrain and accompanying effort required to cross it, land size, and degrees of security or harm encompassed in the environment.

- Once these elements are known, you can **accurately determine the best strategies to approach the land.**

The Leadership relates to the constitution of leaders and how it affects their ability to command successfully. **A good leader should display the combined qualities of intelligence, trustworthiness, humaneness, courage, and sternness.**

- Depending on one quality over another or dismissing one completely creates a broken link in the leader’s ability to be effective.

Discipline means the level of structure and organization within the ranks. How troops and officials are organized is as important as material preparations, such as supplies and weapons, for the success of military action.

- **Both soldiers and leaders need to be disciplined in their training.**
- If either is not prepared sufficiently, fear and confusion on the battlefield are likely.

Using Knowledge to Gain Advantage

First, you should assess these five traits regarding *your* forces. Then, **assess these five traits for your opponent** to size up the competition.

- If you understand both your strengths and efficiency and those of your enemy, you can realistically compare the two and predict the likelihood of victory during conflicts.
- **You should prepare to enter into conflict only when the outcome shows the likelihood of success for your side.**

Many leaders are aware of these advantageous traits, but only those who incorporate them into their leadership practices will succeed.

- For instance, if you know your opponent is a savage leader, their relationship with the civilian population will likely include discord.
- If there is discord between civilians and leadership, there may be a lack of support for your opponent's actions.
- This type of discontinuity can expose vulnerabilities in their tactics, which provides you with opportunities to attack.

Assessments and Advantages in Battle Strategy

The key to any successful battle strategy is the assessment of the five traits so as to know yourself and your opponent fully. You must be willing to be pliable and adapt, when necessary, based on the information generated by this assessment.

Strategy should be developed as a consequence of advantage. A course of action that is not pliable will fail because the strategy cannot adapt to new events. A leader must assess each event that occurs and take advice to see where subsequent advantages lie and proceed accordingly.

Battle strategies covered by Sun Tzu include deception, reading the enemy, wearing the enemy down, and using spies.

Deception

The goal of any conflict is to control your opponent and overcome them. Controlling their beliefs about your abilities helps you understand their assumptions and plan a strategy accordingly. As a well-known translation of Sun Tzu puts it, **"all warfare is based on deception."**

Deception includes feigning weakness when you are strong or professing ignorance when you are informed. Appearing to be weak, unprepared, or small in size can lure your opponent into traps and make them susceptible to misguided actions or responses.

For instance, creating a scenario where only a small portion of your force is visible can mislead opponents into thinking they outnumber or outarm you. When they prepare an attack under that guise, they will be ill-prepared for the full strength of your forces.

Another example is allowing your opponent to win small victories or gains. Your opponent may fall victim to greed or an inflated ego, which will confuse and hinder their strategy when the truth is revealed.

Historical Example: Manipulation through Deception

When a Chinese emperor was strategizing an attack on the Han dynasty, which had joined forces with the Huns, he sent a scout to scope out the Huns' forces. Ten scouts returned after seeing old and feeble men milling about and reported that the Huns were weak. However, one scout, Lou Jing, saw the placement of these men as a ruse and reported that an attack would be unwise. The emperor punished Lou Jing for this advice and sent a massive force into Hun territory.

Lou Jing had been right. The hidden Huns forces surrounded the emperor's men and stranded them for a week without supplies.

Reading the Enemy

As stated, knowing the strength of your opponent is vital. **Once you have fully assessed your opponent's capabilities, you must understand how to use the information to bolster your position.**

If the enemy is operating from a foundation of fullness, meaning all facets of the five traits are viable, you should keep a close eye on them and start organizing your forces. Ensure that your side is equally "fulfilled" and aware of possible conflict. Avoid conflict until your enemy's situation changes.

- When your opponent sees that you mean not to engage in the conflict, a gap may open up. They may relax and provide an opportunity suitable for attack.
- Also, your lack of action may begin to anger the opposing leadership.
- **Continue to find ways to anger and irritate your opponent, for decisions made out of anger are often petulant and rash, which can lead to advantages for you.**

Once you notice that your opponent is riled up or angry, back off to give them the delusion of superiority or success. They may become arrogant or lax in their judgment, from which carelessness extends.

- **If the enemy deems that you are no longer a threat, they will underestimate you or dismiss you as an opponent.**
- This arrogance creates the perfect environment for you to successfully attack them.

Wearing the Enemy Down

In addition to manipulating a strong enemy into carelessness, **forcing the enemy to exert energy will create opportunities of advantage for you.**

Strategize your efforts so they are geared toward controlling your opponent's momentum. These tactics include surprise attacks, retreating when they advance, advancing when they retreat, and maneuvering them in different directions.

For example, you might strike a certain portion of the enemy's forces to push them down a particular path in defense. When their energy shifts to take up this defense, switch your assault to the enemy troops in the

opposite direction. Switching attack positions forces your opponent's defense to hustle down another path to defend against your advance.

Moving them back and forth by forcing them to react to conflict, rather than allowing them to initiate conflict, will keep them on their toes and tire them out.

Using Spies and Aggravators

Since no strategy is complete without assessing the enemy, one of the most important aspects of any conflict is the use of spies.

Send someone to infiltrate the enemy's ranks to create discord. These spies can create rifts between the soldiers and leaders or among individual ranks through false information.

If members of the opponent's team begin to distrust the leadership or covet the spoils they enjoy, harmony among the ranks will be destroyed. **When there is disunity in your opponent's ranks, you have gained an advantage.**

Likewise, treating the enemy's populace better than the enemy treats them can swing loyalties and create division. Dissension can also be created between the enemy and their allies, which divides their sources of power.

When the enemy is distracted or distressed by this division, attack.

Change Your Strategy as Needed

A good leader ensures that their strategy is not open to infiltration or manipulation. Therefore, **a good leader keeps their strategies secret, even from their own troops.**

One way to ensure your strategies remain unknown is through adaptation. **Strategies should be fine-tuned through assessments of enemy action, not completely mapped out beforehand on a drawing board.**

- If your forces consistently use the same tactics or procedures, regardless of the situation, the enemy will be able to predict your actions.
- Instead, use your knowledge of the enemy's foundation to inform your decisions about how to proceed once you've seen how they are preparing.

This is not to say that you should not have a clear plan before battle. You must prepare your forces for victory by developing a rich and focused approach. **Victorious leaders plan their victories ahead of time before entering a conflict.** Only after this foundation is set can adjustments be made strategically.

- It's the difference between (a) carrying a full deck of cards and deciding which card to play at different points in the game and (b) starting with one card and picking up the ones you'll need along the way. Start with a full deck so you have cards to play when needed.

Exercise: Preparing for Battle

Sun Tzu provides a number of considerations required once conflict with an opponent has been developed. But how do these considerations translate when applied to your own personal conflicts?

When was the last time you were in conflict with a person or group of people? What was the conflict about?

What would your first strategic maneuver be now regarding this conflict?

What other tactics might you employ to thwart your opponent's efforts?

Chapter 2: Setting the Stage for Victory

In order to set the stage for victory, you need to manage both your resources and your forces wisely.

Wise Resource Management

One way a mishandling of resources leads to defeat is through extensive and exhaustive battles. **Extensive and lengthy operations deplete your reserves.** Thus, an intelligent leader will not keep his troops in the field for lengthy periods.

- Waging war is like igniting a fire. If the flame burns too hot for too long, it will burn itself out.
- Similarly, engaging in extended battles without gain will exhaust your resources, including weapons, money, energy, and food. This will weaken your troops and lead to loss.

Therefore, battles should be swift. **Be big and bold, attacking quickly and ferociously, then retreating.**

Tactics for Ensuring Ample Resources

Use your enemy's resources when possible to sustain your troops. Build your armor from your home stores, but when you win the battle, nourish your bodies with the enemy's food. Feeding off the enemy's food supply has three benefits:

1. You save your resources for when they are really needed, such as during a lengthy campaign.
2. You reduce the resources of the enemy, leaving them vulnerable to an attack.
3. You don't have to take food from your homeland, which leaves nothing left for the people and leads to poverty.

Also, take into account that costs of goods near a place of battle will inflate, which causes a strain on the locals' finances. This scenario can leave a country impoverished as goods are depleted and spending increases.

- For example, if the battleground is close to home, local proprietors of goods will raise their prices to benefit from the military presence.
- As food prices increase, many locals will be unable to afford those goods or overextend their finances to afford them.
- Further impacting locals, the supply of goods will be used up quickly by the military. When there is no more food, the locals will suffer.
- They will have no money available for the procurement of goods from other sources.
- Without food and money, the quality of life for the locals will decrease.

Lengthy campaigns create a negative situation for the homeland, whether the battleground is nearby or far away.

- **When resources are depleted through lengthy battles, the people, as well as the military, become exhausted and suffer.**
- If your country is left in peril without resources or money, there will be no one to support your leadership anymore.
- If the military acts intelligently, everyone involved, including those at home, will benefit.

Managing Your Force

You should gather your troops only after an assessment of yourself and your enemy has been made and victory is determined the likely outcome. If you gather troops too soon and have to redo the action down the line when you really need them, the public will be weary and less supportive.

However, gathering the troops is not all that is required to build a strong and successful force. **Ensuring that the troops are rewarded for their efforts will breed motivation.**

- Rewards should be intentional and earned.
- They should be delivered without bias of rank.

Rewards given smartly will encourage the troops to behave in a manner that reaps rewards. On the other hand, rewarding everyone equally or arbitrarily will generate no motivation and deplete your resources.

Likewise, punishments are just as useful as rewards in building the constitution of your force.

Historical Example: Rewards

General Cao Cao was a well-respected and renowned military leader in Chinese history who avidly abided by Sun Tzu's *Art of War*. Toward the end of the Han dynasty (206 B.C.E. to 220 C.E.), Cao Cao often invaded enemy territories. During these raids, he would acquire a trove of valuable treasures, whether rare objects or gold. Whenever these spoils were retrieved, he would divvy them out to those who showed incredible strength and effort. He was generous with his rewards. Those who did not show exceptional prowess or effort received nothing. In this way, his soldiers were motivated to work hard, and he was able to be successful in most of his battles.

Historical Example: Punishments

General Yang Su commanded during the Sui Dynasty (558 to 617 C.E.). He was known for his decisive leadership and swift executions of those who disobeyed his command. In preparation for battle, Yang would seek out troublemakers or those who'd erred for execution. This number could be as low as 12 men or as high as 100.

When it was time to engage in combat, he would send out hundreds of men to attack the enemy. If they failed, he would execute them and send another group. If they failed, the process was repeated. Everyone under his command understood the stakes of failure, and as a result, they always fought hard and were often successful in overtaking their opponents.

Chapter 3: A Thoughtful Plan of Attack

Victory is not just winning the battle. **Killing is not the most important thing. Destabilizing your opponent is.** If the battle is won but the opponent's forces and country are obliterated, that is a lesser victory than if you are able to overcome them and force a surrender.

- If you can weaken your opponent's resolve and force them to concede with their nation intact, your victory is more successful.
- The people will have greater respect for a battle won with integrity than one won through total destruction.

If you prepare your forces and show your prowess in the five traits, you will have won the psychological battle and may avoid a physical one. If the surrender comes before a battle is fought, all the better. **Killing should only be a matter of necessity to survive, not the goal of the mission.**

Strike Preemptively to Avoid Battle

The best time to strike an enemy is when they are involved in preparations. Strike before the enemy is fully mobilized, and they will be unable to fight back. This may prevent a battle. This strategy involves using intelligence, rather than brawn, to win.

If intelligent strategies don't work, the next strategy is to win through intimidation.

- Form alliances to increase your strength to a point where fighting would be ill-advised for your opponent.
- Form alliances with the enemy's allies to disrupt the enemy's power.

Ultimate victory is when battle has been thwarted through intelligence or intimidation, there has been no destruction, no cities have been seized, and no blood has been shed.

Historical Example: Ending Conflict Before It Begins

During the Spring and Autumn Era (722 to 481 B.C.E.), when the Zhou dynasty was beginning to collapse, the state of Jin wanted to overtake the state of Qi, a much smaller state. The Jin sent an emissary to scope out the Qi. The emissary, feigning drunk aggression, insulted the Qi's ruler and tried to force the Qi to disregard etiquette. When the Qi did not react to the insult and did not abide the aggressive demand, the emissary returned home and told the Jin leadership that the Qi were alert, cautious, and prepared. Therefore, they should not be attacked at this time. The Qi were able to thwart armed battle through intelligence.

Prepare Adequately

However, if strategic, psychological warfare does not lead to an early solution, then you may be called upon to physically attack enemy forces. **Attacks should be on enemy forces only**, not territories, cities, or civilians.

- Prepare ahead of time to avoid catastrophe in the field. Sun Tzu says six months are required to prepare the materials for an attack, including weapons and shelters, to avoid malfunctions and casualties. Don't rush into battle without first ensuring that you're adequately prepared. If you fight

from a place of anger and don't take time to prepare, you will be sending your troops to their deaths.

A strategic siege is one where your forces are still strong, your resources still ample, and your casualties are nil.

The Rules for Approaching Enemy Forces

If all traits are equal between you and your enemy, there are rules for how to proceed.

If you have ten times the troops, you should surround the enemy.

- A large differential is needed if you are to enclose them without gaps in the formation.

If your numbers are not large enough to attack, such as only five times larger than those of the enemy, divide your troops into groups.

- Use several groups to broach an attack, and keep a few back to bar against surprise attacks and exploit any enemy weaknesses you observe as the attack progresses.

If you are only slightly larger, such as a two-to-one ratio, divide your troops into two groups.

- Use one group to draw out the opponent, and use the other to attack them unexpectedly.

If you are equal in size and ability, deploy strategies to avoid direct combat.

- Use strategies of division to disrupt the enemy's power, then engage in ambushes and surprise attacks.
- If this strategy is not possible, go on the defensive and stand your ground.
- Don't get pulled into battle if you are not sure of victory.

If you are smaller or weaker, avoid conflict and flee.

- Again, **engaging in battle without the assurance of victory is a foolish strategy.**
- After retreating, build up your defenses and see to the nourishment of the troops.
- Wait for a gap in the enemy's strategy or for the enemy to relax, then strike.

Understanding Appropriate Strategy

The strategy of your troops must be malleable based on circumstances. **If you try to control the troops only after conflict has begun, you will be thwarted or outmaneuvered.**

If you know your strengths and abilities and measure them as effective against your opponent, you can enter conflict prepared for anything. If you only know your strength and not your opponent's, you will enter conflict blindly.

- When you understand the essence of your enemy, you will know how to approach battle against them.
- When you understand your essence, you will know where you are vulnerable and how to mitigate impact.

Historical Example: Knowing When to Fight

At the beginning of the new Tang dynasty (618 to 905 C.E.), the founding ruler wanted to wipe out rebel armies from the former Sui dynasty still on the attack. When the ruler and a fellow warrior scouted the rebel army, they saw they were at a disadvantage sizewise. The warrior cautioned that attacking the rebels head on would be impossible. He suggested fortifying their position to tire them out and deplete their resources. The rebels expended much energy to instigate a battle with the Tang and ran out of food by nightfall. When they started to retreat, the Tang army followed and overpowered them.

Exercise: Sizing Up the Competition

You know that intimate knowledge of your enemy is essential to any good battle strategy. This information can go a long way in helping you determine the best way to approach conflict.

Think of a conflict in the past that was not resolved in your favor. What knowledge of your opponent would have been useful ahead of time? Why would it have been useful?

What tactics could you have used to gain this information?

Chapter 4: Organizing Your Forces

The formation that a group of forces takes signifies the psychological state of those forces. How you organize your troops provides insight into the stability and ability of your strategy and forces. Therefore, the formed express volumes and the formless express nothing. Be sure to hide your troop's formation.

Likewise, the stance or formation of your enemy indicates their psychological state. However, you cannot force your enemy to take a stance. You must understand that victory can be predicted but not created.

- If your enemy fails to expose themselves through formation, you cannot know whether victory is certain.
- If victory is not certain, you should not attack. You can only prepare your own troops.

Defense vs. Offense

Defense means laying low and becoming unseeable. Within strategy, aim to appear formless, or unorganized, to keep the enemy from attaining insight into your forces. But keep your troops organized, and be prepared for the opposition.

- **A good defense is the appearance of formlessness.**
- Be defensive when victory is uncertain or you are lacking yourself.
- Cover your tracks and appear unorganized until a vulnerability appears in your enemy, then switch to offense.

Offense means attacking swiftly and decisively, bursting forth with the strength of a thunderstorm. If you attack quickly and with strength, it will be impossible for your opponent to prepare or react.

- **Be on offense only when you have more than enough power to ensure victory.**

It is impossible to gauge the volume of water pooling in a deep canyon. Similarly, when your forces are hidden on the defense, your opponent cannot gauge your volume and strength. Like the release of the deluge, your offense will be massive and overwhelming.

The Easy Victory

A victorious leader wins first and battles second. Therefore, a good leader takes advantage of opportunity, wherein they succeed when winning is easy. An easy victory means understanding the nuances of your opponent in order to preemptively strike.

- Stand on advantageous ground by taking into consideration all circumstances that create vulnerability in your opponent.
- Another way of thinking about advantageous ground is creating a strategy that is so inscrutable and adaptable that defeating you becomes close to impossible.
- You have a contingency for everything, making you always prepared.
- You know your opponents so well as to be able to recognize even the slightest weakness and exploit it.

Historical Example: The Consequences of Battle Without Strategy

Toward the end of the sixth century, two empires were in conflict for supremacy: the Zhou and the Qi. The Zhou ruler wanted to attack a valuable Qi territory, but one of his advisors cautioned against it. The advisor expressed concern over the large and highly trained Qi forces tasked with defending the territory, stating that even if they attacked with their full strength, they would not be able to take the territory easily, if at all. He suggested attacking a smaller, less valuable territory, where victory was more assured. The Zhou ruler ignored this warning and went ahead with the attack, losing the battle and many men and resources along the way.

Chapter 5: Mobilizing an Attack

Using force means allowing the momentum of the conflict to move your hand. A good leader allows momentum, not the brawn of the troops, to provide efficiency of strategy. **Let momentum work in your favor, and victory will require little effort.**

Momentum can be created by manipulating your opponents. **Make your opponents follow the path you lay out for them.** When they are on your path, you know when and how to attack.

- Assuming a formation to create a false perception of your troops will cause your opponent to take a certain shape, one you've manufactured and control.
- Dangle a carrot in front of your opponent by convincing them of manufactured gain, and you will know what their next move will be.

When you force your opponent into action, you can see the ins and outs of their preparedness and strength. You can determine their behavior patterns when you create scenarios where they are forced to act.

Orthodox vs. Unorthodox Action

In battle, fighting is unremarkable. It is straightforward in action. But victory is attained through the remarkable. Unremarkable and remarkable actions are also referred to as orthodox and unorthodox actions, respectively.

Both orthodox and unorthodox actions are taken during conflict. **Ensuring victory means having a command of both orthodox and unorthodox actions.**

Orthodox actions are straightforward techniques—tried and true behaviors and formations.

- For example, fighting on the front lines or attacking a valuable territory are orthodox actions.

Unorthodox actions are surprise attacks and other maneuvers outside the typical boundaries of battle.

- For example, ambushes and deception are unorthodox tactics.

Orthodox and unorthodox tactics should be blended to work in harmony. Like the endless combination of colors derived from the five primary colors, there are multiple variations encompassed within the primary actions of orthodox and unorthodox behaviors.

- Orthodox behavior is always direct, and unorthodox behavior is always a surprise.
- But the manifestation of each is endless in its possibilities.

Manipulate what your enemy views as orthodox and unorthodox behaviors. **By feigning orthodox behavior, you set your opponent up for attack through unorthodox action.** For instance, *disorganization* emerges from *organization*, *fear* emerges from *bravery*, and *vulnerability* emerges from *strength*.

- If you want to appear unorganized, you must first be organized.
- If you want to appear cowardly, you must come from a place of courage.
- If you want to appear weak, you must start from a foundation of strength.

- These deceptions will mislead your enemy.

Deception is a great way to gain information about your opponent. If they think you are weak and they attack, you know the level of their aggression and greed.

Any time you can confuse or deceive the opponent, you force them to adapt. In these adaptations, you can discern their patterns of movement, strength of force, and tendencies to react.

- This information becomes useful in determining how to strategize against them.
- You will know in which situations they will fight and which they will run.
- You can determine when lives will be threatened and when lives can be saved.
- You can find out where the gaps in their strength are, otherwise known as vulnerabilities.
- With this information, you can strategize when attacking is beneficial and when defending is more beneficial.

Do not repeat tactics or strategies. The possibilities of orthodox and unorthodox actions are endless, so constantly adapt both to serve the momentum and remain mysterious.

Use Momentum Strategically

It is not enough to simply feign orthodox behaviors to make your enemy vulnerable to unorthodox attacks. Even if you have organization, bravery, and strength on your side, if you do not adequately address the five traits of success, the result will be actual disorganization, fear, and vulnerability.

Some situations can give a misleading appearance of preparedness. For example, when momentum is on your side, even the fearful can find courage. Relying on this fraudulent strength is foolhardy. If you lose the force of momentum, the courageous can become scared.

Determine the strength of your forces based on merit, then place them appropriately to benefit from momentum. If you position your troops in this way, your strength becomes like a boulder rolling downhill. By the time the boulder reaches the bottom, its velocity makes it unstoppable.

Historical Example: Exploiting Momentum

In 265 C.E., the martial emperor of Jin defeated Cao Cao's forces in the north and wanted to overthrow another kingdom, the Wu, to gain supremacy in the south. One of Jin's generals won a small battle against a faction of the Wu's military. The general then asked for permission to carry out a full assault on the Wu. Knowing the large amount of strength, supplies, and men it would take to overthrow the Wu, the emperor denied the request, suggesting they wait a year to prepare.

The general, in response, cautioned that their plans against the Wu are now apparent. The Wu could begin preparations during the year in anticipation of an assault. The general stated that the momentum was on their side currently, and the likelihood of victory at that moment was large compared to their chances in the future. The emperor agreed, and the general was successful in taking over Wu territory easily.

Exercise: Avoiding the Straight and Narrow in Battle

Sometimes, you need to be creative in how you approach a conflict or an opponent. What constitutes

creative solutions varies from situation to situation.

Have you ever been accused of wrongdoing unjustly? Who was the accuser? What was the accusation?

What were the obvious means of defense and offense?

What other non-traditional or covert strategies could you have used to resolve the situation? How might things have turned out differently?

Chapter 6: Resilience vs. Vulnerability

Sun Tzu describes two conditions of opponents in conflict: empty and full. Fullness signifies an army who is strategic and prepared and has the advantage. Emptiness signifies an army who is reactive and unprepared and is at a disadvantage.

- You must avoid battle with people who are full.
- You must never battle when you are empty.
- **The only mode of success is to strike the empty with the full.**

Part of being full means always having the advantage. Staking claim to a battlefield first and waiting for opponents to arrive creates a position of comfort. Arriving last and encountering comfortable opponents creates a position of stress.

- If you are first, you are able to prepare. When you are prepared, you are assured and calm and have the advantage.

If you are last, the enemy has the advantage. When the enemy has the advantage, do not approach them. Retreat and go to new ground.

Opponents will follow any path they believe leads to advantage and gain. Opponents will not follow any path they believe leads to harm. Therefore, the act of retreating will give your enemy the impression that you are not able to fight. They may see your retreat as an opportunity for gain, and you may be able to draw your opponent out. You will now be in the position of comfort and advantage on the new ground.

Whoever waits for the fight is full; whoever chases the fight is empty. If you retreat rather than engage when the opponent has the advantage, you will maintain your fullness. By forcing the enemy to come to you, you ensure their emptiness.

Do not follow the path your opponent sets for you. If they have a stronghold in one place, attack a different location to either divide or remove their power.

- If they go right, go left.
- Give your enemy the prospect of gain in front of them, then attack them from behind.

Six Tactics to Gain Advantage

1) Draw your opponents out. By continuing to draw your opponent out, you cause them to give up their advantage. You force your opponent to focus their strength in a particular direction.

- If they are comfortable, make them mobilize.
 - Leaving a place of comfort creates stress.
 - Forcing them to continually be on the defensive creates exhaustion.
- If they are healthy and sufficient in supplies, attack their supplies.
- When they are on defense, attack a vital target to ensure their offense.

2) Be formless. You attack where they are not so they don't know where to defend. You defend by laying low so they don't know where to attack. **When you are formless, your opponent will not be able to**

generate intelligence and cannot adapt.

- This will confuse the opponent. They will become wary of your strategies and reluctant to engage in conflict.

3) Attack what is dear to them. If your opponent attempts to be formless, draw them out by attacking what is dear to them. They will not be able to resist defending and rescuing what is important to them.

- When you force your enemy to take a form while remaining formless, they will naturally spread themselves thin to cover all bases.
- While they are occupied with that, you remain intact and fully manned. Once they are divided, your consolidated strength can attack their divided strength.
- The more defensive positions you manipulate your enemy into establishing, the more diminished their power will become.

4) Be prepared. You must be the designer of the *when* and *how* of battle. **If you always know when and where the fight will take place, you can always be prepared.** In not knowing the logistics of the battle, your opponent will be overly alert, wear themselves down, and be unable to form a strategy.

- If you do not know when and where the fight will take place, even if you are stronger, you are at a disadvantage and victory is uncertain. Therefore, if the battleground is unknown, do not fight.

5) Be adaptable. It has been said that military force is like water: like the flow of water is determined by the terrain, the force of military action is determined by the opponent. The ability to shapeshift according to the actions of your opponent is intelligence. When the enemy is to blame for your victory, it is genius.

6) Don't let your strategy get out. If the enemy knows where you will strike, they will amass their powers to oppose you there. Similarly, if you show your hand by adopting a form, your opponent will be able to see where you are strong and where you are vulnerable.

Historical Example: Forcing Enemy Formation

The Warring States Era (480 to 246 B.C.E.) saw lengthy civil wars among the various kingdoms and is the era in which *The Art of War* was written. During this time, the states of Wei, Zhou, Han, and Qi were all viable. The Wei and Zhou joined forces against the Han, who sought assistance from the Qi in defense. The Qi, despite being a much smaller state, set out toward the Wei kingdom with the intent to attack.

The Wei general, upon hearing this news, left his station in Han territory and headed home. He was arrogant about the weakness and cowardice of the smaller Qi army.

The Qi commander sought the advice of Sun Tzu, who told him to have his army set a thousand fires the first night. On the next evening, the army was to set half the amount and repeat the process of the following night.

Hearing of the dwindling fires, the Wei general felt assured of victory and pompously took an elite force to wipe out the Qi. Concurrently, the Qi general estimated the timing of the Wei's movements. He found a narrow section of road by which the Wei would be traveling at night and created a barrier across it: a large tree trunk with words carved into the side. He then surrounded the area with archers. When the Wei general approached the log, he lit a torch to read the engraving. The archers,

now with an illuminated target, sent multitudes of arrows into the enemy. Seeing that his men were losing and that he'd fallen into a trap, the Wei general took his own life.

Chapter 7: Fighting the Good Fight

Struggle is the energy required to gain advantage. Combat is the toughest form of struggle, meaning it is the hardest way to gain advantage. However, there are easier ways to gain advantage.

Location, Location, Location

When the path to battle is long, resources are used and troops tire. This makes either you or your opponent weakened and vulnerable to attack. Therefore, **use the distance traveled for battle to your advantage.**

- When your journey to battle is long, double the speed of travel to arrive sooner than expected. Your opponent will be relaxed as they wait and unprepared for your early arrival.
- When your opponent's journey to battle is short, force them to take circuitous routes to lengthen their journey. Forcing the enemy to defend multiple points or cherished locations disrupts their straight path.

When you travel far for battle, you are in enemy territory. The terrain is unfamiliar. Until you know the advantages and disadvantages of the land, you cannot prepare a strategy. **Use local guides to assist in understanding the environment.**

- The *IChing* states, "Chasing deer without a guide only takes you into the bush."

To gain advantage in a foreign place, you must use deception to manipulate the enemy.

- Feign your condition to fool enemies.
- Divide and combine forces to exhibit false formations while you are actually formless. False formations confuse and mislead the enemy.

Act only when you have an advantage. When no advantage is seen, create a strong defense and hold your ground in a way that is not seen.

- Be immovable as a mountain and as secret as fire, destroying every trace of where you have tread.
- When you have gained advantages in the war, divide your troops to defend what was gained so you can expand your territory.

Three Other Considerations During Armed Struggle

1) **Use signals to gain fullness and force emptiness.** Signals are a way of organizing your troops and confusing the enemy.

- Use drums and banners to draw multiple ears and eyes to the same message. Drums and banners signify unity among your troops so all are linked under the same umbrella.
- Use signals to send false messages to enemies, such as setting more fires than there are troops (as in the example in the previous chapter) or raising more banners than there are squads.

2) **Understand the nature of energy and how it leads to advantages.** Energy is the key to any successful mission. Energy is strong in the mornings, wanes in the afternoon, and depletes in the evening.

- **A good leader does not strike the energized.** They wait until the energy has waned or depleted to strike.

Morning also means early in the battle, afternoon means mid-battle, and evening means the end of battle.

- If conflict has gone on for too long, the energy of the enemy's troops will wane, and they will be more vulnerable.
- Psychologically, even the most timid soldier is brave when energized. But as their energy fades, fear and remorse will infiltrate their minds.

3) When you surround your enemy, leave an opening for escape. An enemy who sees no way out will fight with everything they have. They are desperate and are willing to fight to the death. In contrast, an enemy who sees an opening will try to maneuver through it—then you know what their next move is..

Remain Steadfast in Your Strategy

Once you have prepared your strategy and are capable of adapting, put your mind at ease. **Do not be persuaded by the actions of the enemy or dangling carrots of gain or victory.** Set your plan and stick to it.

- If you see the enemy adjusting and losing focus because of events or prospects of gain, attack, for they are disorganized and emotional.

Do not get emotional and be forced into action. Stand your ground, remain controlled, and maintain fullness.

- If the enemy suddenly retreats, don't assume weakness and attack. It may be a feigned retreat and a setup for an ambush.
- If the enemy abandons provisions, do not snatch them up. Abandoned provisions may be poisoned.

Do not fight an enemy on higher ground, and do not fight an enemy who has the momentum.

Do not attack an enemy on their way home. They will do whatever it takes to make it home. They will be braver when the end of their struggle is near.

Historical Example: Using Distance as an Advantage

After the fall of the Han dynasty, three kingdoms—the Wu, Shu, and Wei—battled during what was known as the Era of the Three Kingdoms (190 to 265 C.E.). The general of Shu joined forces with the Wei, becoming a military governor of what was called "New City." However, soon after, he defected to the Wu, again switching his allegiance.

The Wei general was advised by his commanders to send scouts to observe the actions of the Shu and Wu before reacting. But the Wei general wanted to take advantage of the uncertainty of loyalty that would necessarily follow such a flip-flopping of allegiance. The Wei general sent a force to New City, traveling day and night. Meanwhile, the defector assured his commanders that the Wei was too far away. He said his troops would be fortified and ready by the time the Wei learned of his actions and mobilized.

When the Wei arrived eight days later, surprising everyone with their swiftness, they easily pushed through the defector's ill-prepared army and forced a surrender.

Chapter 8: Flexibility in Leadership

A good leader knows how to adapt to make any situation an advantageous one. You must have a flexible mind to be able to see advantages in the land and in your position and make use of them. If you maintain a constant stance or structure, you may also reveal your form and weakness of mind to the enemy, which puts your troops in harm.

Be willing to adapt your strategy accordingly depending on the circumstances. If you merely allow the momentum of forces to serve as a guide for action, your advantage will never change.

If you try to push your troops without the benefit of adaptation, even if your force is bigger, you will have a hard time gaining the trust of your troops. If your troops don't trust your judgement, they won't fight for you.

Rules of Adaptation

The ability to adapt means having contingencies in place when momentum is not on your side. It also means doing the opposite of what seems advantageous in the moment. The following are rules for adaptation:

- Have plans in place for how to handle being surrounded or backed into a corner to balance your disadvantage.
- Avoid action that seems too easy, such as taking a direct route when there are areas on the route that could lend to ambush.
- Don't attack a weakened enemy when you see that they have nothing to lose.
- Don't attack an easily taken territory if the locals are loyal and there is an abundance of supplies on hand.
- Don't attack a territory when keeping it secure would require more effort than what is gained.
- Dismiss the orders of your civil leaders when they lead to emptiness for your troops.
- Do what is right for advantage, not what is right for greed.

The Psychology of Adaptation

Understanding your strategy facilitates adaptation, as does understanding the mindset of the enemy.

Psychology plays an important role in actions and counteractions during battle. For instance, what hinders your competitor is the threat of harm. What ties up your competitor is work. What energizes your competitor is possible gain.

- Make your enemy believe harm will come from attacking you, and they will thwart themselves.
- Confuse the enemy with deception and formlessness, and they will work overtime chasing you around.
- Tempt the enemy with profit, and they will be easily persuaded.

Assume the enemy will enter conflict and attack, and prepare for it before it is even broached.

There are five ways you can do more harm than good as a leader.

- If you have no fear of death, you can be killed.

- If you have too great a fear of death, you are vulnerable to capture.
- If you have a hot temper, you can be lured into foolish situations.
- If you are self-righteous, you can be offended easily.
- If you are too benevolent, you can be lured into rescue traps or hesitant to take the necessary actions.

Therefore, you should not be resigned to death or feel that life is too precious. Be guided by strategy and momentum only, thereby being immune to goading or flattery.

Historical Example: Tempting the Enemy into Formation

During the Spring and Autumn Era, the state of Chu wanted to attack the state of Jiao. The Chu general knew that the Jiao were small and led by volatility. He also knew they had a reputation for chasing opportunities for gain.

He sent a force of unarmed men into Jiao territory under the guise of chopping wood. The men were quickly captured, and the taste of victory grew heavy in the mouth of Jiao's leaders. Bolstered by this capture, the Jiao sent a force to chase the Chu into the mountains. However, the Chu, knowing the Jiao would not be able to resist this goading, were lying in wait. When the Jiao forces rushed the mountains, the Chu ambushed them and attained victory.

Exercise: How Flexible Are You?

The ability to pivot and adjust your plans accordingly is vital to any successful campaign. However, change can be difficult, especially in high-stress situations.

When was the last time you were forced to adapt your plans because of outside influences?

Were you receptive or resentful of the need to adapt? Why?

What benefits were created because of the changes you made?

Where are you currently being inflexible about your plans? How can you be more flexible to get into a stronger position?

Chapter 9: Maneuvering with Advantage

How you maneuver your troops should be based on advantage. Be aware of the advantages and disadvantages involved in any action.

Reading the Environment

Water

When a body of water crosses your path, the following advantageous maneuvers should be considered.

- Avoid the water if possible.
- Do not meet an enemy in water. Wait for half of them to cross, then strike.
- Do not face the current of a river or head against the flow.
- Do not anchor your boats downstream -- the enemy may ride the current down the river and destroy your troops on impact.
- If it rains and the river is white-capped and turbulent, wait for the water to calm down if you must cross.

Land

Use the land to your advantage. Always keep your back toward the most advantageous direction. Choose level ground, for it is easy to cross. If level ground is not available, take a high position.

- High ground allows the momentum to swing downward.
- Low ground is often overgrown and damp, which can lead to illness.
- When people are in the dark or are wet for too long, they can become depressed and sickly. Maintain good physical health, and stay close to resources.

If part of the land is treacherous or barricading, keep to the far side of it and face it.

- Your enemy will be forced to remain close to the disadvantageous land and will have their backs to it.

If you enter dense territory, with deep forests and brush cover, search them thoroughly. The enemy may be hiding in wait.

Study the landscape.

- If the trees shake, the enemy is advancing.
- If the animals stir and birds fly up, there are people lying in wait.
- If there is a lot of dust, it means vehicles are moving around.
- If there is light dust, it means the enemy is setting up camp.
- If the dust is close to the ground, it is caused by foot traffic.
- If birds gather in a certain area, there is no disturbance there.
- If there are disturbances in the undergrowth, be mindful. It may be a trap or misdirection.

Reading the Enemy

Look out for signs of the enemy's behavior, interpret them to understand the enemy's weakness, and react

accordingly.

Signs of Exhaustion, Thirst, or Hunger

- If the negotiator is irritable, it means they are exhausted.
- If the enemy requires fortification to stand upright, they are weak and hungry.
- If enemy troops are sent to fetch water for the group and those sent pause to drink first, their entire group is thirsty.
- If the enemy hands out numerous punishments, they are trying to motivate tired troops or are reacting to worn-out troops who are not able to follow commands.

Signs of Fear

- If you see that the enemy has an opportunity to gain advantage but they do not react, they are weary.
- If you hear enemy calls in the night, they are communicating fear. Calling out in the night is a way of connecting with each other for security.

Signs of Imminent Retreat

- If an enemy negotiator shows aggression and strength, don't react. They may be trying to intimidate you because they aim to retreat.
- If the enemy hands out numerous rewards to their troops, they are trying to distract them from a loss of momentum.

Signs of Poor Leadership

- If the enemy's troops are discombobulated or angsty, their leader is not considered competent.
- If the enemy's signals are all over the place, they lack unity and organization.
- If enemy troops are seen cavorting among themselves and fall behind in their duties, they are becoming disloyal to their leader.

Signs of Manipulation

- If an enemy negotiator comes speaking of peace but carries no treaty, be wary. The enemy may be stalling to manage some issue with their troops or distract you from an ensuing attack.
- If the enemy divides its power and sends half to attack while the other half retreats, they are trying to manipulate you to chase them.
- If the enemy becomes aggressive but does not attack, be ready for an ambush. They are trying to distract you.

Signs of Enemy Advantage

- Be mindful of your opponent's positioning. If they leave from a strong position and move to another, there must be some advantage to them doing so.
- If the enemy orchestrates a mass of forces, expect their reinforcements to follow shortly.
- If the enemy depletes their food supplies and abandons essential cooking tools, they are at the end of their rope. The troops now have nothing to lose and will fight to the death.

Historical Example: **Suspicious Surrender**

When one of Cao Cao's rivals surrendered to him, Cao Cao allowed the rival to return home. Shortly after, the rival returned to attack Cao Cao and killed Cao Cao's son and nephew. Cao Cao also suffered an arrow injury.

The rival returned again with an armed force, but Cao Cao was successful in defending against them. On reflection, Cao Cao blamed his benevolence and negligence in letting the rival go for the fate of his family and army, advising his commanders to never make such an egregious error.

Considering Your Troops

Having the largest force does not equate to winning the battle. If you have a smaller force, hold your ground, gather the troops you have, keep an eye on the enemy, and prepare a defense.

Even if you have the largest force, if you rely on strength alone, fail to strategize, and take your enemy's forces for granted, you will be defeated.

If your troops are punished without first gaining their trust and loyalty, they will withdraw emotionally and will be hard to mobilize.

Likewise, if your troops become too attached to you and are spared punishment, they will become cocky and difficult to manage.

In sum, treat your troops humanely but govern them strictly. They will respect your command and trust you, thereby becoming loyal and fierce warriors.

Historical Example: The Benefit of Strict Governance

The kingdom of Qi was invaded by Yan and Jin during the Spring and Autumn Era. In response, one of the Qi nobles recommended a man, Rangju, from outside the Qi territory to advise the Qi leadership. Rangju was known for his strength in battle and positive relations with the public where he came from.

However, when Rangju was made a general for Qi, he requested the service of a familiar nobleman to lead the army, since his authority was challenged by the lack of familiarity and trust by both the Qi fighters and people. A nobleman was appointed, but when called upon, his ego led him to attend a farewell bash instead of heading to the military meet-up position.

When he finally arrived, Rangju ordered his decapitation, which was the consequence of any military personnel failing to report on time for duty. The nobleman sent a message to the lord of Qi to be pardoned, but he was killed before the emissary returned with pardon. When the emissary returned, he galloped into camp to deliver the message, another crime according to military conduct. Two of the emissary's men were killed as a consequence.

On his own now, Rangju led the army on their mission. When they stopped to set up camp, he behaved as one of the soldiers, getting his hands dirty in the preparations, sharing his supplies, and tending to the sick. After a few days, when it was time to enter battle, all of the soldiers were eager to fight for the fair and authoritative Rangju. This news spread to the Yan and Jin, who knew what such loyalty meant. The Yan and Jin withdrew from Qi territory.

Chapter 10: Land of Opportunity and Danger

Within the strategy of successful leadership, you must understand both the types of terrain and grounds on which battles may be waged. *Terrain* includes all physical elements of the land, and *grounds* refer to the psychological considerations encompassed in the land.

Terrain

There are multiple types of terrain, each with their advantages and disadvantages. **Terrain works as a supplementary member of your force, aiding advantage and victory.** You should have a strong sense of the surrounding terrain. The types of terrain and encompassing qualities are as follows:

Easily passable terrain: Terrain that allows both sides to move freely in and out.

- If you command this terrain first and occupy the easiest routes, you will have the advantage.

Hung up terrain: Terrain that is easy to enter but difficult to retreat from.

- If the enemy has taken this terrain but is not prepared, you can advance with the advantage.
- If the enemy is prepared, advancing brings no advantage and you may become stuck and unable to retreat if necessary.

Standoff terrain: Terrain that is unwelcoming to both sides, thereby creating disadvantages for both sides.

- If the enemy is positioned in this terrain, be wary of opportunities for gain on this terrain.
- If the enemy provides a means for you to gain advantage, hold your ground. They will be forced to either retreat or advance, and you can attack from your advantageous position.

Narrow terrain: Terrain that offers only a small parcel of land.

- If you get to this terrain first, occupy it completely and wait.
- If the enemy gets there first and occupies it, do not advance.
- If they get there first but fail to occupy the space, advance to gain the advantage.

Steep terrain: Terrain comprising any part of the land that slopes.

- Do not fight uphill on this terrain.
- If you get there first, set up high and wait for the enemy.
- If the enemy gets there first, retreat and fortify your defense position.

Wide-open terrain: Terrain that lends no advantages to either side.

- On this terrain, the momentum is equal.
- Do not advance or engage in battle on this terrain because there is no way to gain advantage.

Once you have assessed your opponent and the terrain, you will have a clear picture of where advantages lie and can be victorious. If you don't assess either, you will lose.

The Nine Grounds

There are nine types of “grounds” encompassed in armed conflicts.

Ground of dissolution: Basically a civil war, in which two factions from the same territory war with each other.

- When troops battle close to home, their stability and endurance come into question.

Light ground: When you enter foreign territory but stay along the fringe.

- Light ground allows troops to retreat easily.
- Because light ground is easy to retreat from, the minds of the troops are not yet overcome by the realities of their duty, making them less effective.
- When on light ground, move swiftly to avoid wandering minds and waning courage.

Ground of contention: Land that is advantageous for whoever claims it first, either you or your enemy.

- Examples include any natural barricades or strategic routes.
- If you get to this land first, occupy it.
- If the enemy gets there first, do not confront and attack. They have the advantage of the land on their side.

Trafficked ground: Land with many avenues for entrance and retreat that is easily accessible.

- Allow these routes to stay open so as to not cut off supplies or lose advantage.

Intersecting ground: Land surrounded by population on three sides.

- The first to gain this land gains access to all three territories.
- If you are able to occupy this land and can earn the allegiance of the people, you will win.
- If you do not earn their allegiance, you are in trouble.

Heavy ground: When you enter foreign territory and entrench your troops deep within it.

- Heavy ground is difficult to retreat from.
- Invaders become tougher and stronger the farther they enter into enemy territory.
- Once on heavy ground, your troops become resigned to the fact that there is no easy retreat. They become geared to fight to the death.
- When in heavy ground, amass supplies and treat the locals humanely.

Bad ground: Land with difficult-to-pass natural features and which provides no stability for fortifying your positions.

- Bad ground provides no advantages and should be vacated quickly.

Surrounded ground: Land that is narrow and difficult to get into and convoluted to get out of.

- Surrounded ground allows enemy forces to trap you and defeat you, even if you are stronger.
- If caught in surrounded ground, use unorthodox tactics to fight.

Dying ground: Land on which you can survive if your attack is swift and die when it is not.

- The land is such that movement has become restricted and your only choice is to fight.
- When your troops know there is no way out but to fight, they will do so with all their strength.

Understanding How Grounds Equate to Victory

By nature, leaders place their troops in harm's way. Thus, all aspects of terrain, ground, benefits and dangers, and humanity must be assessed.

Therefore, when considering the state of your troops in relation to the grounds, the strategy is as follows:

- Create emotional and mental unity among the troops on ground of dissolution.
- Maintain contact on light ground.
- Keep your troops close and agile on ground of contention.
- Fortify your troops' defenses on trafficked ground.
- Create strong alliances on intersecting ground.
- Provide proper provisions on heavy ground.
- Push your troops forward on bad ground.
- Tighten your front on surrounded ground.
- Be honest about death on deadly ground.

Historical example: Forming Alliances

During the Three Kingdoms Era, the Shu army surrounded a faction of the Wei military. Cao Cao, a Wei general, wanted to relocate the rest of the Wei's capital away from enemy lines for safety. But a minister of Wei advised against such an action, stating that it exuded weakness. Instead, he said they should form an alliance with the state of Wu. The Shu and Wu were considered to be allies, but the minister knew this was only a surface appearance. He assumed the Wu leadership would begrudge the Shu gains.

Cao Cao agreed and sent an emissary to create an alliance with Wu, who was tasked with attacking the Shu from the back. The Wu were successful, and the Shu retreated from its position surrounding the Wei army.

Exercise: What Ground Are You On?

Sun Tzu's description of the nine grounds provides insight into how to approach certain environments. With this knowledge, you can understand what type of ground you are on and how to approach it.

Think of someone with whom you are frequently in conflict. How would you describe the type of ground existing between you?

With this knowledge, what strategies might you use when confronted with this type of conflict again?

What are the disadvantages for you encompassed in this ground?

Chapter 11: The Use of Weapons

Weapons are not relegated to guns, tanks, and ammunition. A weapon is any physical element that assists in battle.

Fire Attacks

Fire attacks come in five forms: burning people, burning provisions, burning tools, burning storage facilities, and burning arms. The use of fire should be rational and for a purpose.

Use fire not to destroy but to create opportunities. The use of fire should be to cause a disruption or vulnerability in your enemy or confuse them. When using fire attacks, the strategy is to follow-up swiftly to take advantage of the mayhem caused.

- Once the fire is raging, it's time to attack.
- When the fire has died down and people are back in control, the window for attack is closed.

Understanding when to set a fire means understanding the essential conditions for fire. Even if you would prefer to use fire in a different way, if the opportunity presents itself and conditions are right, take advantage.

- Fire is best set when the conditions are dry and windy, thereby allowing nature to help the fire grow.
- If you set a fire upwind, attack upwind.
- Do not put your troops in the line of fire.
- Do not go rogue and set fires when the conditions are not favorable.
- Know how to safeguard against a fire attack by using the weather patterns as guides.

Arms

The use of arms should be considered carefully and only when all other tactics have been exhausted. **The main goal of conflict is to avoid direct battle and defeat.**

Only mobilize armed forces when there is no choice but to do so. Do not allow anger, pride, or petty grievances to guide your decisions.

Only go to battle when it is advantageous or easy to do so. If it is not, do not advance.

Emotions are malleable. They come and go with the seasons. But a broken nation cannot be rebuilt to its former self, and the dead cannot be resurrected. Remember these solemn truths when deciding whether or not to use arms.

Chapter 12: Espionage At Your Disposal

Knowing your opponent is vital to any successful conflict outcome, and part of knowing your opponent is understanding their conditions. Therefore, **people are the most reliable and gainful sources of intelligence about the enemy.**

There are five types of spies: the local spy, the inside spy, the reverse spy, the dead spy, and the living spy. **Genius in strategy is when all five types of spies are in use** and remain unknown to all but you.

Local spies: Spies generated from the locals in any territory.

Inside spies: Spies currently serving as executives in the enemy's ranks.

- There may be disgruntled officials within the opponent's ranks, those overlooked for promotion, those laid off, those unfairly treated or punished, and those who are overly ambitious and greedy.
- Some inside spies will be people who wish to push their own agendas or jump ship before their side is defeated.
- Some are just untrustworthy or conniving people.
- Some may be relatives of mistreated or condemned officials.
- These people can be turned with a bribe or promise of personal gain.
- Once turned, their benefit comes in alerting you to enemy strategies, conditions, and advancements against you. Or, you can use them to drive wedges inside the enemy's ranks.

Reverse spies: Enemy spies who have been pinched and rehabilitated.

- If you can bribe enemy spies and treat them more humanely than their leaders treat them, you can create a double agent to use to your benefit.
- Reverse spies can be enticed into sharing secrets or carrying fraudulent information back to their leadership.

Dead spies: Spies you use to provide the enemy with false information.

- Dead spies are manipulated by you to spill bad information to the enemy.
- Once the enemy discovers the information is fraudulent, the spy will undoubtedly be killed.

Living spies: Spies who gather information and return to your basecamp to report.

- The best living spies are those who appear innocent and simple but are in fact cunning and clever.
- These spies should be forgettable on the outside but stalwart on the inside.
- They should be courageous, trustworthy, immune to flattery and persuasion, and able to overcome a variety of negative conditions, whether personal, natural, or psychological in nature.

The Role of the Spy

The secrecy involved with using and maintaining spies is on level with the necessary secrecy of strategy. Spies are some of the most cherished and rewarded individuals among the ranks, for their contribution is vital. Therefore, **it is imperative to treat spies well so as not to entice them to revert to reverse spies for the enemy.**

There is a mutual understanding between a good leader and a spy.

- A job well done will garner the spy rich rewards.
- A failed job will lead to the spy's death.
- If information is received before a spy returns with the information, both the spy and the messenger should be killed.

Likewise, spies are only as good as the intelligence of the people who govern them.

- A successful spy is one provided informed orders, so do not use spies when you lack sufficient knowledge of the enemy.

When you are ready to attack or advance, use spies to provide the required information about the players involved on the enemy's side.

Use reverse spies to inform actions regarding other spies.

- Reverse spies can provide intel on locals who are willing to inform on the enemy or simply greedy, thus easily persuaded to join forces with you.
- Reverse spies can tell you how to manipulate the enemy.
 - This information allows you to understand what information to send through dead spies.
- Reverse spies also provide information on the conditions of the enemy.
 - This information allows living spies to traverse enemy territory successfully and return home.

All other brands of subterfuge are possible through information gleaned from reverse spies. This is why reverse spies are the most advantageous and should be rewarded the best.

The use of spies is not a choice but a necessity. A good leader knows who to use and how to use them with a high level of intelligence.

- The necessity comes from the need to know the enemy as you know yourself.
- This type of inside information cannot be achieved to a satisfactory degree through any other means but espionage.

Historical Example: The Benefit of Reverse Spies

During the sixth century, there was a general of the court of Zhou who was well-liked, charismatic, and good at his job. He employed many spies within the court of Qi and the Qi community, and his generosity and benevolence made them loyal. Therefore, Zhou knew everything that was happening in Qi.

The Zhou general devised a plan to plant a song within the Qi kingdom that suggested the prime minister of Qi was planning a coup against his military. A Qi spy helped spread the song, and a rift grew between the prime minister and a Qi general, leading to the former's execution. Once the Zhou general learned of the execution, he launched an attack against the Qi kingdom and destroyed it.

Exercise: Who Are Your Allies?

People are an important commodity in any conflict. Differentiating between those who provide support and those who are untrustworthy is vital if you want to gain advantages over your opponent.

Who are the people you can lean on in times of conflict?

How can you use your relationships with them to gain advantages in times of conflict?

Is there anyone you currently wish you had more information about?

Who might be able to assist you in attaining that information and how?

Chapter 13: Final Thoughts on Leadership

A good leader is a steward of survival not only for the forces they command, but also for the entire nation. Therefore, **if a leader encompasses the qualities of intelligence, trustworthiness, humaneness, courage, and sternness, the nation will be strong.** If, however, a leader is lacking in one or more of these qualities, the nation will be weak.

- Leaders must be both loyal and capable.
- They must be able to concoct successful strategies that are unknowable and unpredictable.
- A good leader does what is best for their troops, as well as their nation.

There are five ways of determining which leader will be victorious during a conflict.

1. The leader who knows when and when not to engage in battle.
2. The leader who understands what sort of manpower is needed and when.
3. The leader who has created harmony among the ranks.
4. The leader who has prepared a strategy ahead of time.
5. The leader who knows when and when not to listen to government commands.

Prowess in Leadership

Victory is formless to outsiders. The public is aware of the win but unaware of how the win manifested. Simply understanding a victory is not the same as having wisdom about how to win. Therefore, **a good leader understands the nature of victory in a way laypeople cannot fathom.**

Victories of good leaders should not be categorized as brave or cunning. **A good leader does not win by luck, accident, or exertion.** They use wisdom to win before the battle has even begun.

Keep the formation of victory a secret from the public. Keep the knowledge of the masses focused on the result of victory, not on the tactics of victory. Then your strategies will always be formless.

Similarly, be mysterious even within your own ranks. Keep your troops ignorant of the overall strategy. If they are only aware of your commands, they only have forward-looking vision and can be led like sheep. They know their role is to follow your command and nothing more. The troops are there to carry out the conclusion of the strategy, not help create the strategy.

As well as guarding your strategy from the troops, guard the dangers and disadvantages, as well.

- Do not make them fearful of the tasks ahead.
- Keep them motivated with thoughts of advantage.
- When danger comes upon them, they will voluntarily mobilize to survive.

Ignorance in Leadership

A good leader always takes into account the dangers as well as the advantages when determining action. The mark of defeat is when a leader does not consider advantages and disadvantages. They either rush into battle, react too slowly, are susceptible to emotional disturbances, and fail to conceal strategies. For this leader, defeat is not an occurrence but a consequence.

There are six ways poor leadership leads to defeat.

- Not examining the size of their troops and those of their opponents.
- Not instituting a system of rewards and punishments, or instituting one that is not strictly enforced.
- Poorly training and preparing their troops.
- Having a poor disposition or being easily emotionally disturbed.
- Being unable to command and maintain control of their ranks.
- Not considering the strengths and weaknesses of their troops.

Further Considerations

If a leader does not form alliances, establish authority, and refrain from anger and violence, they will be alone, ineffective, and vulnerable. If a leader can create this situation in their enemy, the enemy will be unable to defend against you.

Troop Management

A good leader takes stock of their troops and determines which are strong and which are weak.

A good leader knows that both rewards and punishments are required. One without the other leads to either a state of complacency or resentment, which negatively affects the troops ability to fight effectively.

A good leader fortifies their troops, ensuring they are fed and healthy, monopolizes on early energy and reserves energy for when it is needed, remains formless and mysterious in defense, and remains patient until the momentum and advantages are in their favor and the enemy shows vulnerability.

When a leader is organized and consistent in leadership, the strong and the weak come together to fight under the same umbrella. When they consider the terrain and take advantage with this combined force, victory is certain.

- When they generate this type of synchronicity in their forces, they can lead them as though they were one person.

When the situation is dire and there is nothing left to lose, a good leader knows they don't need to mobilize and encourage their forces. Everyone understands the stakes and fights with the same aim voluntarily.

Positioning

A good leader lays low and fortifies their defenses when they see no opening to attack the enemy. They wait for an opportunity by maneuvering according to the actions and behaviors of the enemy.

- If the enemy is strong and resentful, a good leader they will appear weak and ashamed, manipulating the enemy into egotistical emotions of superiority.
- If the enemy shows a desire to retreat, a good leader will they allow them to mobilize and head home.
- Both of these actions trick the enemy into a place of complacency, making them ripe for attack.

When faced with a large enemy force, a good leader determines where advantageous terrain lies and occupies it, then disrupts the enemy's supply chain.

- A leader should take hold of anything considered advantageous and dear to the enemy so the enemy will be forced to abide by their plans.

A good leader strikes like a snake with four heads, so the front is the back and back the front. Therefore, anywhere the enemy attacks is within striking distance.

Momentum

A good leader is swayed by the momentum of battle and acts within those boundaries regardless of orders from civil government.

- This leader advances without hopes for personal gain, retreats without fear of personal loss, and acts only in a way that is advantageous for their troops and nation.
- All decisions are aimed at protecting the nation's people.

To be able to gain advantage when the enemy is unprepared and unalert, a good leader must be swift in action. Hesitation will be the death of their forces.

Once the strategies for battle are clear and the time to fight is upon them, a good leader ties up loose ends, closes the borders, and refuses entrance or exit to negotiators.

Deception

A good leader gets their opponent to open the door and appears innocent so as to be let in. Once in, they wreak havoc like a virus.

A good leader uses tactics to confuse and discombobulate the opponent, drives wedges among the enemy's troops and populace, relies on unorthodox and orthodox tactics, and strikes when it is advantageous and can be done in a way that leaves the enemy without time to prepare.

A good leader is never stagnant. They constantly adapt their strategies, routes, and encampments to keep not only the enemies in the dark and on their toes, but their troops as well.

Historical Example: A Properly Trained Force

Confucius stated that allowing forces not properly trained to enter battle is the same as abandoning your forces in enemy territory.

Another leader, Wu Qi, a general for the Wei state, advised that the first task of any military action is to properly train the forces. Teach a few to fight, and they will expand and teach others to fight, and so on until a large fighting force is amassed.

Soldiers must be trained in all the tactics and strategies possible within a conflict, such as when to strike and when to retreat, when to fortify and when to divide, and when to use resources and when to feed off the enemy. Only after they have learned and mastered these skills and considerations should they be given weapons. Creating experts in battle before providing the tools of battle is the foundation of a good leader.

Exercise: The Art of War in the Real World

Now that you've read about the strategic and psychological considerations involved in successful leadership and conflict resolution, test and apply that knowledge.

Conflict is a natural part of life. What are three considerations you will take into account the next time you find yourself in conflict with an individual or organization?

What principle from *The Art of War* feels the most applicable to your life?

How would you describe the strategies of *The Art of War* to your friends and family?